

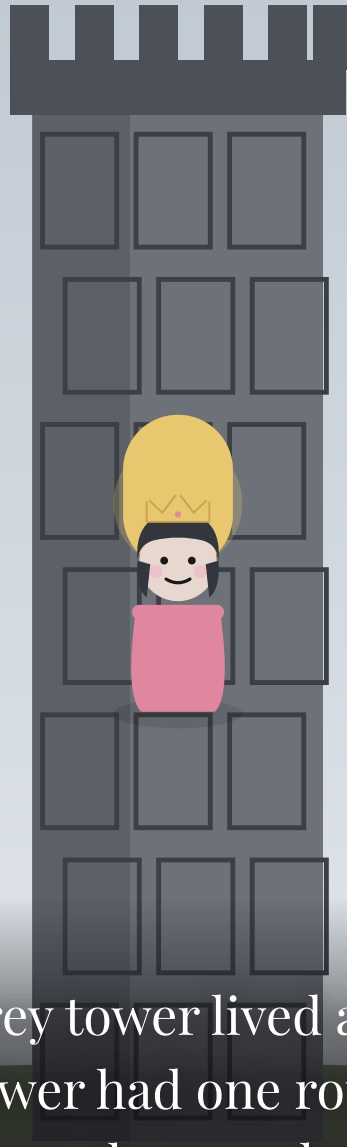


THE LITTLE REWRITES

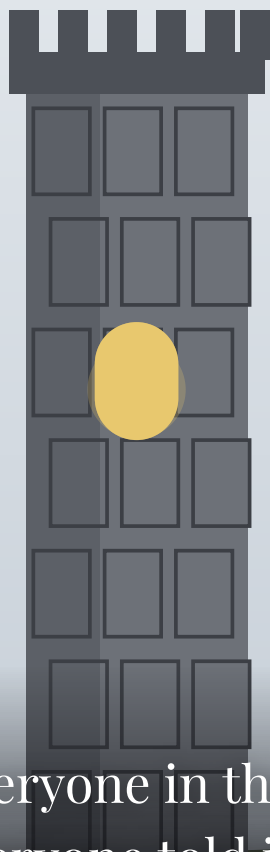
THE PRINCESS WHO RESCUED HERSELF

A fairytale about writing your own happily ever after.

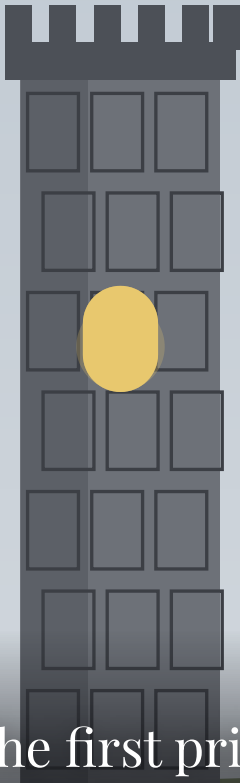
MK PARRISH



At the top of a tall grey tower lived a princess named Wren. The tower had one round window, one very heavy door, and exactly one rule for a princess: *wait*.

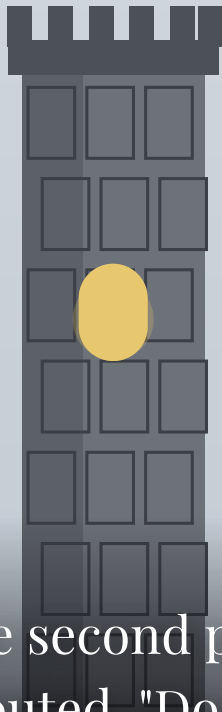


Everyone in the kingdom knew the story, and everyone told it the same way: one day a brave prince will climb the tower, open the door, and set the princess free. So Wren waited. That was, everyone agreed, the whole point of her.



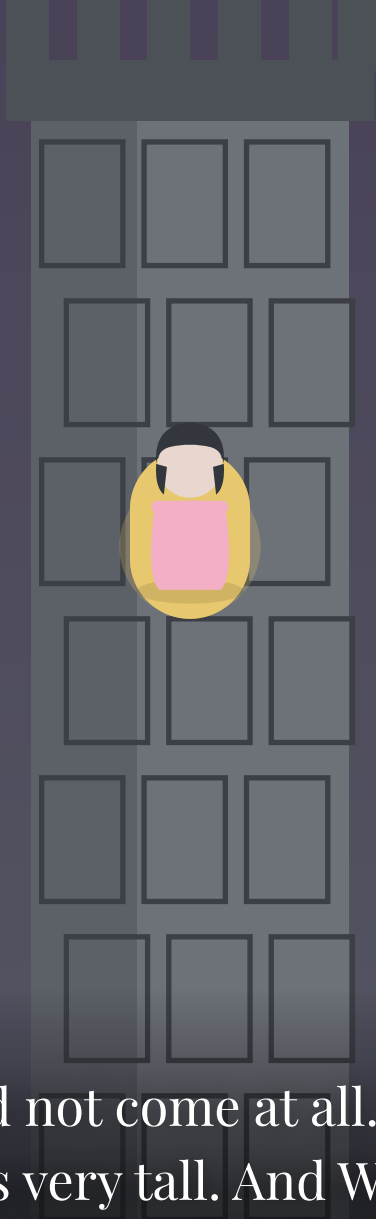
HMM.

The first prince rode up on a fine white horse, looked at the heavy locked door, said, "This looks rather *difficult*," and rode off to find an easier tower.



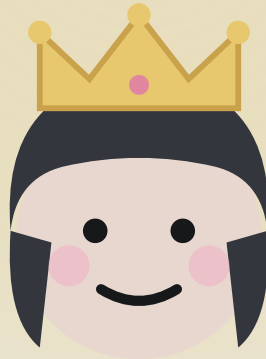
zzz...

The second prince stood at the bottom and shouted, "Do not worry — I am here to rescue you!" Then he sat on a rock to rest from all that shouting, fell fast asleep, and by morning had forgotten which tower it was.



The third prince did not come at all. He had heard the tower was very tall. And Wren sat by the round window with her chin in her hands, and something in her that had been quiet a long time finally cleared its throat.

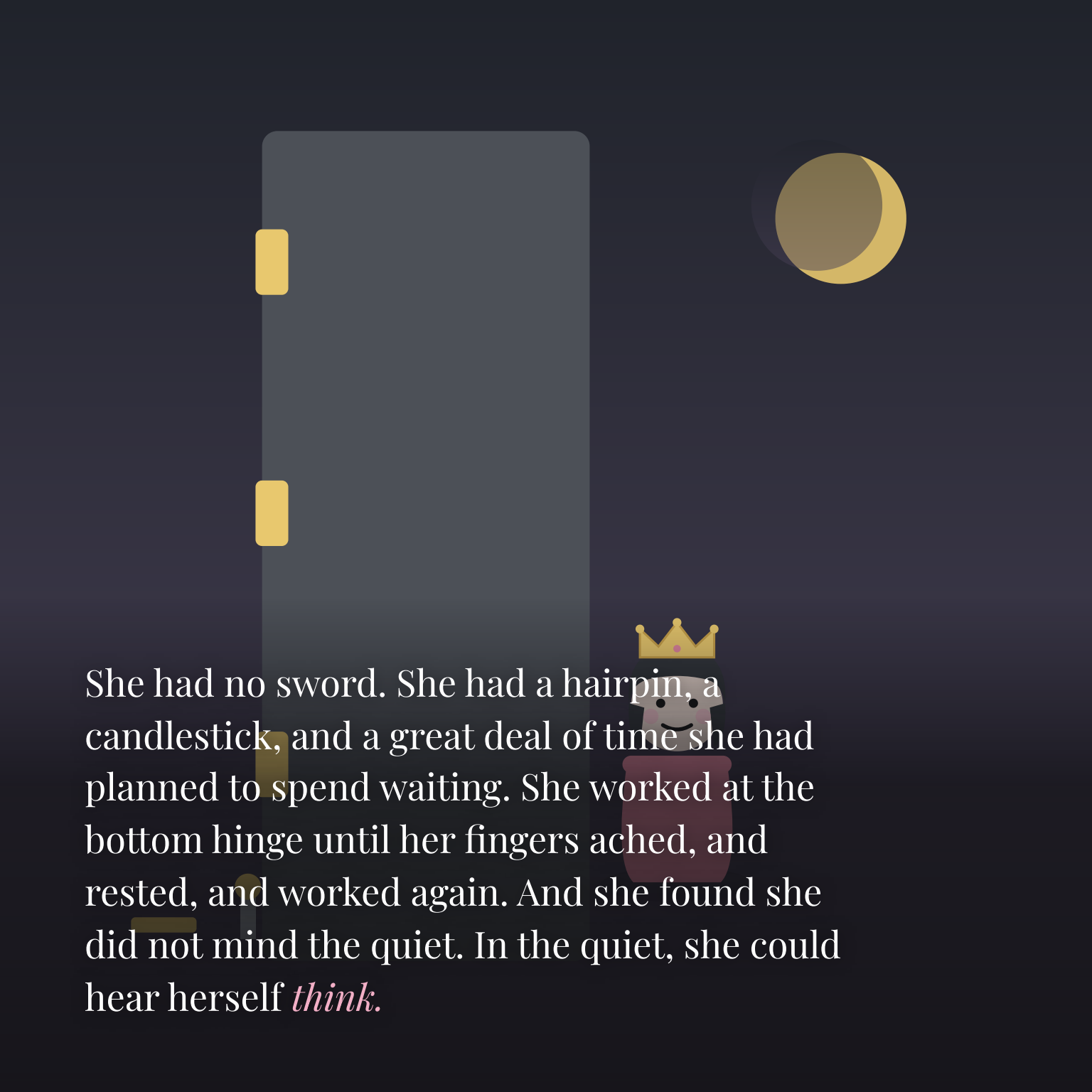
why wait?



"Why," thought Wren, "am I waiting for someone who keeps *not coming?*" It was a small thought. But small thoughts, in towers, echo.



She walked to the door and looked at it properly — the way you look at something you have decided is *yours to solve*. The lock was on the outside. But the hinges — the hinges were on the *inside*. Nobody had ever mentioned the hinges.

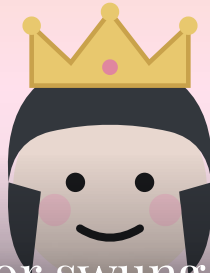
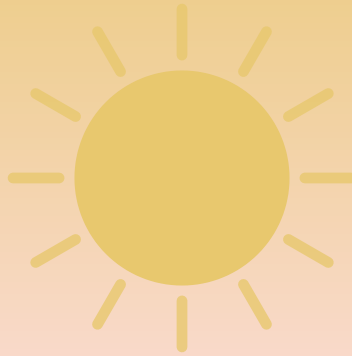


She had no sword. She had a hairpin, a candlestick, and a great deal of time she had planned to spend waiting. She worked at the bottom hinge until her fingers ached, and rested, and worked again. And she found she did not mind the quiet. In the quiet, she could hear herself *think*.

GROAN...



By the time the moon was high, the bottom hinge came loose with a groan. By the time the birds woke, the top one did too. And Wren pushed — not at the silly lock, she left that exactly where it was — she pushed at the *hinged* side.



And the great heavy door swung the wrong way entirely — the way nobody ever expected a door to swing — and fell open into the morning. Wren stood at the top of her tower with the wind in her hair and the whole green kingdom spread gold below her. She had not been rescued. She had been *paying attention*.

but... who rescued you?

On the road she met the first prince, very startled to see her walking freely about. "But — who *rescued* you?" he asked. Wren thought about it. Then she smiled, and told him the truest thing in this whole book.





"I did," said Wren. And she walked on into her own morning, in no particular hurry, because it was hers now — all of it. The road, the kingdom, the story. Especially the story. She had picked up the pen, and written herself a door.

FOR THE GROWN-UP READING ALONG

We give little girls a story early: something is wrong, and a prince will come and fix it. It is a lovely story and a terrible plan. This one keeps the tower and the prince and the happily-ever-after — and quietly hands the pen to the girl. When you finish, ask the small person listening the question the whole book is really about: *"What would you do, if the door was locked and nobody was coming?"* You may be surprised by how quickly they look for the hinges.